

# GALLANT IAS

## ANCIENT INDIA

### MODULE 1

## INDIA DURING THE PRE-HISTORIC PERIOD

### SOURCES TO CONSTRUCT ANCIENT INDIAN HISTORY

#### ARCHAEOLOGICAL REMAINS AND MONUMENTS

Ancient ruins, remains and monuments recovered as a result of **excavation and exploration** are archaeological sources of history. The archaeological remains are subjected to **scientific examination of radio-carbon method** for its dates. They give us some knowledge of the **life of the ancient people**. India is rich with ancient ruins, remains, and monuments.

#### INSCRIPTIONS

Inscriptions supply valuable historical facts. The **study of inscriptions is called epigraphy**. The study of the writings on ancient inscriptions and records is called **paleography**. Inscriptions are seen on **rocks, pillars, stones, slabs, walls of buildings, and body of temples**. They are also found on **seals and copper plates**. **Political, administrative and religious matters** are gathered from such sources.

#### NUMISMATICS

The **study of coins** is known as numismatics. Coins form another source of historical information. Ancient coins were mostly made of **gold, silver, copper or lead**. Some of the coins contain **religious and legendary symbols** which throw light on the culture of that time. Coins also contain the **figures of kings and gods**. Some contain **names and dates of the rulers**. Coins also throw significant light on economic **life of ancient people**. They indicate **regarding trade and commerce** and help to reconstruct the history of several ruling dynasties. The coins of the **Kushana and the Gupta** period give interesting accounts of those days. They throw light on religious, political, economic and commercial conditions.

#### LITERARY SOURCES

##### RELIGIOUS LITERATURE

The Religious Literature of India is too vast. It includes the **Vedas, the Upanishads**, the great epics like the **Ramayana and Mahabharata**, and the Puranas of the Hindus. These are like mines of information about religious beliefs, social systems, people's manners and customs, political institutions, and conditions of culture.

The religious writings of the **Jainas and the Buddhists** are also enormous. They include the Jatakas and the Angas etc. Contemporary **economic and social conditions** are vividly known from these sources.

##### SECULAR LITERATURE

**Kautilya's Arthashastra** is a famous work. It not only speaks of the **State and polity**, but also of **socio-economic system**. Authors like **Patanjali and Panini**, though they wrote

**Sanskrit grammar**, also described some political events. The dramas of **Kalidasa**, **Vishakhadatta**, and **Bhasa** give us useful information about the people and society. There were some historical writings too. **Bana wrote Harshacharita** or the Life of Harsha. **Bilhana** wrote about Vikramaditya. **Kalhana's Rajatarangini** was a historical text of great value. It is an account of the history of Kashmir. It presents the career of the Kings in chronological order.

### **ACCOUNTS OF FOREIGNERS**

From very ancient times, foreigners visited India. Some of them left valuable accounts of their travels or visits. Ancient Greek and Roman historians also wrote about India from their knowledge and information. All these foreign accounts prove useful for writing history.

The **Greek ambassador Megasthenes** stayed in the court of Chandragupta Maurya and wrote his famous work **Indika** which spoke **Mauryan polity and society**.

From **Pliny's** work we know of trade relations between **Rome and India**. These writers wrote in early centuries of the Christian era. The **Chinese traveler Fa-Hien** left valuable accounts on the time of the imperial Guptas. **Hieuen Tsang**, who is described as the 'Prince of Pilgrims' wrote details about the India of the age of Harsha. Another Chinese, **Itsing**, visited India in 7th century A.D. His accounts contain the **socio-religious condition** of those days. Historians construct history from various sources to present the truth of the past to the men of today and the future.

### **PREHISTORIC AGES IN INDIA**

The history of human settlements in India goes back to prehistoric times when there was no paper or language or the written word, and hence **no books or written document**, to record the events in the life of primitive people. However, **plenty of archaeological remains** are found in different parts of India to reconstruct the history of this period. In India, the prehistoric period is divided into the **Palaeolithic** (Old Stone Age), **Mesolithic** (Middle Stone Age), **Neolithic** (New Stone Age) and the **Metal Age**. Out of them, **Palaeolithic** (longest) and **Mesolithic** represent **hunting-gathering** stage while the **Neolithic** represents the **stage of food production**, i.e. **plant cultivation and animal husbandry**.

However, these periods were not uniform throughout the Indian subcontinent. **The dating of the prehistoric India is done scientifically**. The technique of **radio-carbon dating** is commonly used for this purpose. It is based on measuring the loss of carbon in organic materials over a period of time.

### **PALAEOLITHIC OR OLD STONE AGE**

Palaeolithic Age spanned from 2 million years ago {when tool making members of Homo erectus had arrived} till 10,000 BC. It is divided into three period's viz. **lower Palaeolithic middle Palaeolithic (50000BCE to 40000BCE)** and **upper Palaeolithic**

**(40000BCE to 10000BCE)** ages. The transition from each of these phases to successive phases was slow and marked by increased fineness in the stone tools and technology of the time as follows: Lower Palaeolithic age tools – Handaxe and cleaver, Middle Palaeolithic age tools – Flakes Upper Palaeolithic tools – Flakes and blades Further, this division is not uniform around the world because of several factors such as **time lag, climatic changes, great distances, numerous geographical and physical barriers** etc. **Palaeolithic age** finally ended with the end of **Ice Age** in about 10,000 BC.

Some of the famous sites of Old Stone Age in India are:

- **Kurnool** in Andhra Pradesh
- The **Siwalik hills** on the north India.
- **Bhimbetka** in Madhya Pradesh.
- The **Soan valley** and **Potwar Plateau** on the northwest India
- **Adamgarh hill** in Narmada valley.
- **Attirampakkam** near Chennai.

In the Old Stone Age, food was obtained by hunting animals and gathering edible plants and tubers. Therefore, these people are called as **hunter-gatherers**. They used **stone tools, hand-sized and flaked-off large pebbles** for hunting animals. **Stone implements** are made of a **hard rock** known as **quartzite**. Large pebbles are often found in river terraces. The hunting of large animals would have required the combined effort of a group of people with large stone axes. We have little knowledge about their language and communication. Their way of life became modified with the passage of time since they made attempts to domesticate animals, make crude pots and grow some plants. A few Old Stone Age paintings have also been found on rocks at Bhimbetka and other places. The period before 10000 B.C. is assigned to the Old Stone Age.

### **MESOLITHIC OR MIDDLE STONE AGE**

The next stage of human life is called **Mesolithic** or **Middle Stone Age** which falls roughly from 10000 B.C. to 8000/6000 B.C. It was the **transitional phase** between the **Paleolithic Age** and **Neolithic Age**. Mesolithic remains are found in **Langhanj in Gujarat, Adamgarh in Madhya Pradesh** and also in some places of **Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh** and **Bihar**. The **paintings and engravings** found at the **rock shelters** give an idea about the **social life and economic activities of Mesolithic people**. In the sites of Mesolithic Age, a **different type of stone tools** is found. These are **tiny stone artifacts**, often not more than five centimetres in size, and therefore called **microliths**. The hunting-gathering pattern of life continued during this period.

However, there seems to have been a shift from big animal hunting to small animal hunting and fishing. The use of bow and arrow also began during this period. Also, there began a **tendency to settle for longer periods in an area**. Therefore, **domestication**

**of animals**, and primitive cultivation started. **Animal bones** are found in these sites and these include **dog, deer, boar** and **ostrich**. Occasionally, burials of the dead along with some microliths and shells seem to have been practiced.

### **NEOLITHIC AGE**

A **remarkable progress** in the **prehistoric India** is noticed in the **Neolithic Age**. It is approximately dated from 6000 B.C to 4000/1000 B.C. Neolithic remains are found in various parts of India. These include the **Kashmir valley, Chirand** in Bihar, **Belan valley** in Uttar Pradesh and in several places of the **Deccan**. The important Neolithic sites excavated in south India are **Maski, Brahmagiri, Hallur** and **Kodekal** in Karnataka, **Paiyampalli** in Tamil Nadu and **Utnur** in Andhra Pradesh. The chief **characteristic features** of the **Neolithic culture** are the **practice of agriculture, domestication of animals, polishing of stone tools** and the **manufacture of pottery**. In fact, the **cultivation of plants** and **domestication of animals** led to the **emergence of village communities based on sedentary life**.

There was a great improvement in technology of making tools and other equipment used by man. Stone tools were now polished. The polished axes were found to be more effective tools for hunting and cutting trees. Mud brick houses were built instead of grass huts. **Wheels** were used to **make pottery**. Pottery was used for **cooking** as well as **storage of food grains**. Large urns were used as coffins for the burial of the dead. There was also **improvement in agriculture**. Wheat, barely, rice, millet were cultivated in different areas at different points of time. Rice cultivation was extensive in eastern India. **Domestication of sheep, goats and cattle** was widely prevalent. **Cattle** were used for **cultivation and for transport**.

Some scholars divide the Neolithic settlements into three groups – **northwestern, northeastern and southern**, based on the types of axes used by the Neolithic settlers.

### **CHALCOLITHIC (COPPER-STONE)**

The Neolithic period is followed by Chalcolithic (copper-stone) period when copper and stone came to be used. The new technology of **smelting metal ore** and **crafting metal artifacts** is an **important development in human civilization**. But the use of stone tools was not given up. Some of the micro-lithic tools continued to be essential items. People began to travel for a long distance to obtain metal ores. This led to a network of Chalcolithic cultures and the Chalcolithic cultures were found in many parts of India.

### **SIGNIFICANCE**

Chalcolithic area expanded throughout the country except for alluvial region and thick forests. People were settled mostly near hills and rivers. They used **micro lithic tools of stone and copper**. They used **painted pottery** for the first time. Different types of potteries were used by the people of the Chalcolithic phase. The Black-and-Red pottery

among them was quite common. The Ochre-Coloured Pottery(OCP) was also in use. These pots were used for cooking, storing, drinking, and eating. In Peninsular India there was their large village and a large amount of cereal cultivation is known/seen. They grew wheat, barley, lentils, and rice. People from **Kayatha, Inamgaon, and Eran** were well-off while the people from **Chirand** and **Pandi Rajar Dhibi** were poor. In Maharashtra, the dead were buried in north-south direction while in South India in the east-west direction.

### **LIMITATIONS OF CHALCOLITHIC PHASE**

Chalcolithic people could not make full use of domestic animals as they used them **only for food** and **not for milk** (they thought that **milk is for animals' young ones**). They did not do much of cultivation. They lived in **black cotton soil area** which required iron tools for cultivation and there are **no traces of plough or hoe**. People had **no knowledge of mixing two metals** so they could not use the stronger metal bronze nicely. **Copper had its own limitations** and its supply was also less. People were **not aware of the art of writing** and they could not gain any benefit from the technical knowledge of the Indus people.

| <b>PREHISTORIC AGE</b>               | <b>PERIOD</b>                | <b>MAJOR FEATURES</b>                                                                                                                                                                                  | <b>LOCATIONS</b>                                                                                                                                                                          |
|--------------------------------------|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>PALAEOLITHIC (OLD STONE AGE)</b>  | 200000 BC to 10000 BC        | Lower Palaeolithic age tools – handaxe and cleaver, Middle Palaeolithic age tools – flake, Upper Palaeolithic tools – flakes and blades. Hunter-gatherers no domestication of animals, no agriculture. | Kurnool In Andhra Pradesh, The Siwalik Hills On The North India, Bhimbetka In Madhya Pradesh, The Soan Valley And Potwar Plateau On The Northwest India, Adamgarh Hill In Narmada Valley. |
| <b>MESOLITHIC (MIDDLE STONE AGE)</b> | 10000 B.C. to 8000/6000 B.C. | Microlithic stone, transitional phase bow and arrow, domestication of animals, and primitive cultivation                                                                                               | Langhanj in Gujarat, Adamgarh in Madhya Pradesh and also in Some Places of Rajasthan, UP and Bihar, Bhimbetaka                                                                            |

|                                             |                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>NEOLITHIC<br/>(NEW STONE<br/>AGE)</b>    | 8000 B.C to<br>4000/1000<br>B.C | Practice of Agriculture, Domestication of Animals, Polishing of Stone Tools and The Manufacture of Pottery. Village Communities Mud Brick Houses Wheat, Barely, Rice, Millet were cultivated                                            | Mehrgarh Kashmir Valley, Chirand In Bihar, Belan Valley In Uttar Pradesh Maski, Brahmagiri, Hallur And Kodekal In Karnataka, Paiyampalli In Tamil Nadu And Utnur In Andhra Pradesh |
| <b>CHALCOLITHIC<br/>(COPPER-<br/>STONE)</b> | 4000 BC<br>To 1500 BC           | Farming Communities Animals domesticated were Cows, Goats, Buffaloes, Sheep, And Pigs Micro Lithic Tools of Stone and Copper, Painted Pottery Black-and-Red Pottery, No Knowledge of mixing two Metals, not aware of the Art of Writing | Kayatha (Ujjain, MP) Ahar (Rajasthan) Malwa (M.P) Jorwe (Nasik)                                                                                                                    |

### MODEL QUESTIONS (PRELIMS)

- With reference to the people of Neolithic culture in India, consider the following statements:
  - Maski, Brahmagiri were Neolithic sites in South India.
  - They were farming communities and they domesticated animals.
  - They lived in the semi-arid region
 Select the correct statement/statements using the codes given below.
  - 1 and 2 only
  - 2 only
  - 3 only
  - 1, 2 and 3 only
- Consider the following statements
  - The study of inscriptions is called paleography.
  - The study of the writings on ancient inscriptions and records is called epigraphy.
 Which of the statement(s) given above is/are correct?
  - 1 only
  - 2 only
  - Both 1 and 2
  - Neither 1 or 2
- The chief characteristic features of the Neolithic culture did **not** include
  - the practice of agriculture,
  - domestication of animals,
  - polishing of stone tools
  - the manufacture of copper tools.